

# Indigenous History of the Philmont Scout Ranch Region

## Executive Summary

The Philmont Scout Ranch region sits in a cultural borderland where the southern Rocky Mountains, the Great Plains, and the upper Rio Grande world meet. That geography matters: steep elevational gradients, canyon-bottom water, and access to both mountain and plains resources helped make the broader Philmont–North Ponil–Cimarron area attractive to people for millennia. The strongest archaeological evidence shows a long sequence beginning with Paleoindian presence in northeastern New Mexico, followed by Archaic hunting-and-gathering, then a distinctive Cimarron-area farming tradition beginning earlier than in much of northeastern New Mexico, and finally Apache, Ute, Comanche, Spanish, Mexican, and American-era occupations and conflicts. <sup>1</sup>

For Trek 12-15 specifically, the best-documented Indigenous landscape is the **North Ponil Canyon / Indian Writings corridor**. Public and published evidence supports multi-period occupation there, including early farming communities, Ponil-phase rockshelters and houses, later Cimarron-phase settlements in lower canyon and river settings, and historic Indigenous use remembered in regional traditions and Philmont’s own archaeology program. Public Philmont materials also interpret some North Ponil rock art through both **Ancestral Puebloan** and **Jicarilla Apache** lenses, but that ethnic attribution is not equally strong for every panel and should be treated as partly interpretive unless tied to a published panel-by-panel study. <sup>2</sup>

The most defensible historical takeaway for a field guide is this: the Philmont landscape was not “empty wilderness” before ranching and mining. It was a lived-in, traveled, hunted, cultivated, and spiritually meaningful homeland and crossroads. What remains uncertain are the precise meanings of many rock-art motifs, the exact authorship of some panels, and the detailed distribution of nonpublic archaeological sites along all Trek 12-15 segments. Those uncertainties matter, and they are a reason to write cautiously and visit respectfully. <sup>3</sup>

## Methods and Sources

This report prioritizes official and primary-ish public sources in English: the **New Mexico Office of Archaeological Studies** and related New Mexico cultural agencies; **U.S. Forest Service** and **National Park Service** materials; official **tribal** websites where available; peer-reviewed or professional syntheses from the **New Mexico Geological Society** and recent OAS archaeological reports; and official **Philmont** materials where they directly describe public archaeology programming. OAS and New Mexico Historic Preservation Division materials were especially important because they summarize regional archaeology and explain legal protections and confidentiality around site locations. <sup>4</sup>

Assumptions used in this report are explicit. First, “along Trek 12-15” is treated as the currently public travel corridor including **Ponil** and **Indian Writings**, because that is the only portion of this trek with substantial

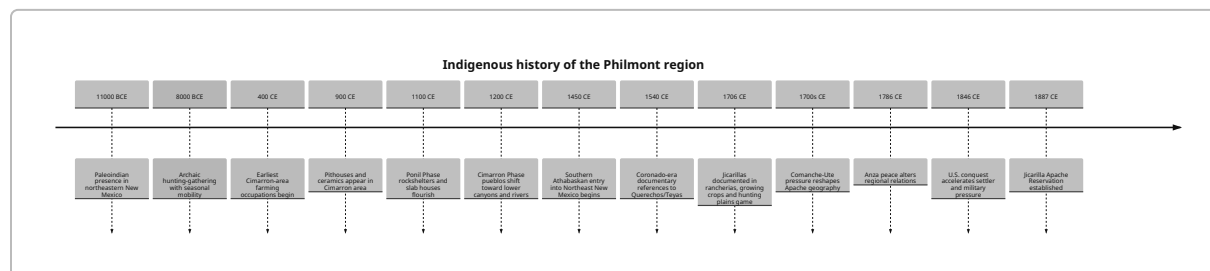
public archaeological interpretation in the sources reviewed. Second, exact site coordinates are intentionally omitted because New Mexico law treats archaeological site locations as confidential, and because federal law protects archaeological resources on public and Tribal lands. Third, older archaeological literature often uses the term “**Anasazi**”; this report uses “**Ancestral Puebloan**” except when paraphrasing older sources or Philmont’s own legacy wording. Fourth, if a trail segment showed no public site-specific archaeology in this review, that means only that no safe public documentation was found—not that Indigenous use was absent. <sup>5</sup>

## Regional Environmental Context

Philmont lies on the eastern flank of the southern Rocky Mountain system, where the **Cimarron Range** rises sharply above the Great Plains and is separated from adjacent basins by major structures and valleys. That topography creates a compressed set of ecological zones: lower **piñon-juniper** woodlands, mid-elevation ponderosa and mixed-conifer forests, and high-elevation spruce-fir and subalpine settings. On the modern Carson National Forest, piñon-juniper commonly occupies roughly **5,900–7,500 feet**, while boreal and subalpine spruce-fir habitat extends into roughly **9,800–12,000 feet**. This ecological stacking helps explain why the broader region supported varied seasonal strategies rather than one uniform way of life. <sup>6</sup>

For archaeology, three environmental features matter most. First, **canyon water** and alluvial bottoms concentrate camps, gardens, travel routes, and later settlements. Second, the mountain–plains ecotone offers access to deer, elk, piñon, wood, and sheltered wintering areas in the uplands, while also opening toward bison country on the plains. Third, the North Ponil/Cimarron corridor appears to have been unusually favorable for early and repeated occupation, which is why the Cimarron District stands out in northeastern New Mexico archaeology. <sup>7</sup>

## Chronological Narrative



The **Paleoindian** record in northeastern New Mexico is anchored by the nearby Folsom tradition. Kirkpatrick’s synthesis emphasizes the importance of the Folsom discovery on the Dry Cimarron, where fluted points were found in secure association with extinct bison, helping establish deep human antiquity in the region. NPS summary material for the broader northeastern New Mexico area likewise describes Paleoindian use tied to Pleistocene bison. **Evidence:** early human presence in the broader northeastern New Mexico landscape is high-confidence. **Interpretation:** direct, site-specific Paleoindian occupation on the exact Trek 12-15 corridor remains unproven in the public sources reviewed. <sup>8</sup>

The **Archaic** period is more weakly resolved, but the consensus is that it involved broader-spectrum foraging with more plant use, recurring use of rockshelters, and seasonal movement between ecological

zones. A recent OAS synthesis notes that Archaic subsistence in northeastern New Mexico likely included plants, deer, and other game, and that comparable northern New Mexico evidence suggests seasonal movement among juniper savanna, mixed conifer, and riverine winter settings. Kirkpatrick also describes Archaic-like occupations in rockshelters in the Cimarron area. **Evidence:** mobile foraging and rockshelter use are well supported. **Interpretation:** the exact seasonal round at Philmont remains reconstructed rather than directly observed. <sup>9</sup>

The **Ancestral Puebloan** sequence in the Cimarron District is especially important because it begins earlier than many other parts of northeastern New Mexico. Kirkpatrick describes the **Vermejo Phase** as the first Puebloan occupation in the district, with circular stone houses, corn, and a date around **A.D. 510**, while noting shallow middens that may imply seasonal, perhaps winter, use. Later phases add storage pits, roasting ovens, pithouses, then the **Ponil Phase (A.D. 1100–1250)** with rockshelters and slab houses, and finally the **Cimarron Phase (A.D. 1200–1300)**, characterized by small multiroom pueblos shifting toward lower Ponil Creek and the Cimarron River. A recent OAS synthesis broadly agrees that the Cimarron area begins unusually early and then shifts from higher canyon settings toward lower canyons and plains margins in later periods. <sup>10</sup>

After about **A.D. 1300**, the broader northeastern New Mexico sequence shows stronger **Plains orientation**, often described through the Antelope Creek focus: agriculture mixed with bison hunting, slab architecture, and combined Plains–Pueblo material patterns. By about **A.D. 1450**, many of those groups had left the area. That transition matters because it sets the stage for later Apache and other Indigenous presences in a landscape already shaped by long occupation, mobility, and exchange. <sup>11</sup>

For the **Apache/Ute/Comanche** era, the strongest publicly accessible synthesis in the reviewed sources comes from the OAS Coyote Canyon report. It places **Southern Athabaskan** entry into the Southwest at roughly **A.D. 1450–1500**, with documentary evidence from the Coronado expedition often read as early Apache references. The same report states that Jicarillas ranged widely across northeastern New Mexico and onto the Plains and that, by **1706**, Spanish sources described Jicarillas living in **rancherías, growing crops**, and also maintaining a **Plains hunting tradition**. Official Southern Ute materials emphasize that Ute peoples historically occupied large parts of Colorado and **northern New Mexico**, and the Southern Ute chronology records both alliance and conflict relationships involving the Mouache/Caputa bands, Jicarillas, Comanches, and the Spanish. Official Comanche history places Comanche southward expansion in the **late 1600s and early 1700s**. <sup>12</sup>

The **Spanish-contact and 19th-century** story is one of increasing political pressure and territorial disruption. OAS synthesis indicates that Comanche pressure, often with Ute involvement early on, pushed Jicarillas and related Apache groups off much of the Plains by the **1730s**; the **1786** Anza peace reduced warfare, but Spanish and then Mexican land-grant expansion increasingly encroached on traditional homelands. After the U.S. takeover in **1846**, American settlement, military campaigns, and changing economic relations intensified conflict. The same synthesis states that a Jicarilla reservation was finally established in **1887**, after decades of displacement and negotiation. In the Philmont area specifically, official Philmont history materials note that Maxwell's move to the Cimarron, later gold discovery near Baldy, and the subdivision of the Maxwell Land Grant transformed the landscape in the second half of the 19th century. <sup>13</sup>

## Lifeways, Seasonal Mobility, and Traditional Ecological Knowledge

**Evidence:** subsistence and mobility changed over time but repeatedly tracked the region's ecology. Paleoindian use was tied to large-game hunting in a northeastern New Mexico landscape that included now-extinct bison. Archaic groups broadened their diet and likely moved seasonally among ecological zones. In the Cimarron-area farming sequence, corn appears early; later sites show storage, roasting, grinding, ceramics, and mixed use of wild and cultivated resources. Jicarilla history in the region combines mountain-valley residence, cultivation, trade, and plains hunting, which is exactly the sort of mixed mountain-plains adaptation the Philmont landscape allows. <sup>14</sup>

**Evidence:** piñon-juniper woodlands had major Indigenous value as food, fuel, and sacred landscape. The Forest Service states that piñon and juniper woodlands have significant Tribal value, including sacred associations and piñon nuts as a staple food source over long periods. More generally, OAS and USFS materials emphasize that heritage resources on southwestern forests connect past ecosystems with living traditions rather than belonging only to the past. <sup>15</sup>

**Evidence:** Indigenous and traditional peoples in the Southwest used fire deliberately for a very long time. A USFS synthesis on traditional fire use stresses that Indigenous and traditional peoples have manipulated landscapes with fire for thousands of years. **Interpretation:** applying a specific local fire regime to Philmont's North Ponil without local ethnographic corroboration would go beyond the evidence reviewed here; the safe claim is that fire knowledge was part of the wider Southwestern Indigenous toolkit and is relevant to understanding these landscapes. <sup>16</sup>

**Evidence:** water shaped both settlement and meaning. Archaeologically, canyon bottoms and river corridors attracted recurrent use. In Jicarilla cultural framing, water remains more than a commodity: a tribal coalition profile describing Jicarilla cultural values emphasizes water's sacred and ceremonial significance and links cultural persistence to land and water. **Interpretation:** one should not project modern public-facing statements backward unchanged into every earlier century, but it is reasonable to understand water respect as a deeply rooted continuity rather than a recent invention. <sup>17</sup>

## Significant Cultural Sites Along Trek 12-15

**Map placeholder and instruction for the guide:** include a small regional map showing **Philmont Scout Ranch, Ponil, Indian Writings**, the **North Ponil Canyon archaeological corridor**, and a separate inset locating the **Folsom Site** as regional context. Use a USGS topographic base plus modern Philmont itinerary mapping. Do **not** plot nonpublic archaeological coordinates; New Mexico law explicitly protects site-location confidentiality, and the most appropriate public map should show only already interpreted public stops or generalized zones. <sup>18</sup>

| Site or zone                            | General location on Trek 12-15                         | Evidence type                                                         | Publicly supportable dating                                                                                                                                                                                                | Confidence                                                                              | Notes and sources                                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Indian Writings public archaeology area | North Ponil Canyon near Indian Writings camp           | Petroglyphs; excavated house remains; active interpretation           | Public Philmont materials place major visible remains around <b>A.D. 900</b> and <b>A.D. 1150</b> ; petroglyph tours interpret pre-1300 occupation, with some Philmont materials also referencing Apache/Jicarilla imagery | <b>High</b> for existence; <b>Medium</b> for specific ethnic attribution of every panel | 19                                                                                            |
| Box Canyon Rockshelter (NP 4)           | North Ponil Canyon, exact site withheld                | Two-room rockshelter; perishable materials                            | <b>Ponil Phase, A.D. 1100–1250</b>                                                                                                                                                                                         | <b>High</b>                                                                             | Kirkpatrick identifies NP 4 in North Ponil Canyon and describes 1941 excavation by Scouts. 20 |
| North Ponil 1 / Slab House              | North Ponil Canyon, exact site withheld                | Multicomponent settlement with slab house, storage, ceramics, lithics | Early component around <b>A.D. 750</b> ; later <b>Ponil Phase, A.D. 1100–1250</b>                                                                                                                                          | <b>High</b>                                                                             | One of the strongest published sequences in the Philmont corridor. 21                         |
| Lizard Cave (NP 2)                      | North Ponil Canyon, exact site withheld                | Rockshelter with hearths, masonry, probable room, pavement            | <b>Ponil Phase, A.D. 1100–1250</b>                                                                                                                                                                                         | <b>High</b>                                                                             | Published as another important North Ponil Ponil-phase site. 22                               |
| Lower Ponil–Cimarron occupation zone    | Trek corridor approaching Ponil and the Cimarron River | Small pueblos, ceramics, later settlement shift                       | <b>Cimarron Phase, A.D. 1200–1300</b>                                                                                                                                                                                      | <b>Medium-High</b>                                                                      | Published as a generalized settlement zone rather than a single public site. 23               |

| Site or zone               | General location on Trek 12-15  | Evidence type                                                      | Publicly supportable dating | Confidence                | Notes and sources                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Baldy-Harlan-Dean segments | Other Trek 12-15 trail segments | No safe public site-specific archaeology identified in this review | Undetermined                | <b>Low / not assessed</b> | This likely reflects confidentiality and research-access limits, not absence of Indigenous use. Consult OAS/ARMS or land-manager archaeologists for controlled research. <sup>24</sup> |

## Archaeological Evidence vs Interpretation

The table below is useful for a field guide because it separates what you can say confidently from what should be framed as a possibility or working interpretation.

| Claim                                                                                                         | Evidence or interpretation                       | Strength           | Why                                                                                                          |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Humans were present in the broader northeastern New Mexico region by Paleoindian times, over 10,000 years ago | <b>Evidence</b>                                  | <b>High</b>        | Folsom-region discoveries and regional NPS syntheses firmly support this. <sup>25</sup>                      |
| Archaic groups used seasonal mobility across uplands and riverine settings                                    | <b>Evidence with interpretive reconstruction</b> | <b>Medium-High</b> | Supported by OAS synthesis and regional comparisons, but exact local rounds are reconstructed. <sup>11</sup> |
| The Cimarron / North Ponil area has unusually early farming occupations for northeastern New Mexico           | <b>Evidence</b>                                  | <b>High</b>        | Published sequence places early farming here as early as A.D. 400–700. <sup>26</sup>                         |
| North Ponil Canyon was a major occupation corridor during A.D. 900–1250                                       | <b>Evidence</b>                                  | <b>High</b>        | Multiple excavated sites, houses, rockshelters, and Philmont interpretation support this. <sup>27</sup>      |

| Claim                                                                                                       | Evidence or interpretation                           | Strength           | Why                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Some Indian Writings petroglyphs are Jicarilla Apache                                                       | <b>Interpretation built on public interpretation</b> | <b>Medium</b>      | Philmont publicly teaches this, but a panel-by-panel published attribution was not located in the official sources reviewed. <sup>28</sup>                           |
| Southern Athabaskans reached northeastern New Mexico by about A.D. 1450–1500                                | <b>Evidence</b>                                      | <b>Medium-High</b> | Supported by OAS synthesis combining archaeology and ethnohistory. <sup>11</sup>                                                                                     |
| Jicarillas in 1706 combined agriculture, ranchería residence, and Plains hunting                            | <b>Evidence</b>                                      | <b>High</b>        | Directly summarized from documentary syntheses cited by OAS. <sup>29</sup>                                                                                           |
| Comanche expansion, sometimes with Ute alliances, displaced many Apache groups from the Plains by the 1730s | <b>Evidence</b>                                      | <b>High</b>        | Strong documentary synthesis in the OAS report and Southern Ute chronology. <sup>30</sup>                                                                            |
| Specific meanings of Indian Writings symbols can be confidently translated for visitors                     | <b>Interpretation</b>                                | <b>Low</b>         | Rock-art meaning is rarely certain without tightly controlled context and community-specific knowledge. Public guides should avoid overreading motifs. <sup>31</sup> |

## Respectful Visitation, Legal Protections, Research Gaps, and Recommended Contacts

For Scouts, the practical rule is simple: archaeological places are not props, souvenir fields, or “mysteries to solve” by touching or moving things. NPS guidance for rock art is direct: do not touch panels, and take only photographs. Philmont’s own guidebook tells hikers to leave artifacts where found and report discoveries to Philmont archaeologists or headquarters. Federal law under **ARPA** protects archaeological resources on public and Indian lands, while New Mexico’s Cultural Properties Act and permit system protect cultural property and site information at the state level. <sup>32</sup>

### Scout checklist

- **Do** stay on established trails and within the public interpretation area.
- **Do** look carefully, photograph respectfully, and report accidental finds.
- **Do** treat rock art, masonry, and excavation areas as fragile and sacred-historical places.
- **Don’t** touch petroglyphs, trace them, chalk them, wet them, or lean gear against them.
- **Don’t** move artifacts, collect flakes or sherds, dig, or rearrange stones.

- **Don't** publish nonpublic site locations or encourage off-trail "artifact hunting."

These points synthesize NPS etiquette, Philmont guidance, and New Mexico site-protection practice.

33

The biggest research gaps are clear. No publicly accessible, official, panel-by-panel scholarly publication of the **Indian Writings** rock art was identified in this review. Much of Philmont's detailed site information appears to remain in restricted records, local field knowledge, older conference papers, or unpublished program materials. Because New Mexico's archaeological records are protected and because sacred significance cannot be inferred from artifact distributions alone, a deeper study should combine archival work with tribal consultation rather than relying only on open web sources. 34

For deeper research, start with these offices: **New Mexico Office of Archaeological Studies** and the **NM Historic Preservation Division / ARMS** for public reports and archival procedures; **Carson National Forest** or Philmont heritage staff for land-manager guidance; **Jicarilla Apache Nation Office of Cultural Affairs / THPO** through the NM tribal contacts list; **Southern Ute Cultural Preservation**; and the **Comanche Nation THPO** for consultation on ancestral-land perspectives. Official public contact pages for these offices are available through OAS, NM HPD, Carson NF, Southern Ute, and Comanche Nation resources. 35

## Annotated Bibliography

**Kirkpatrick, David T. "The prehistory of northeastern New Mexico." New Mexico Geological Society Guidebook 27 (1976).**

Still the most concise published synthesis for the prehistoric sequence closest to Philmont. Especially valuable for the **Vermejo, Ponil, and Cimarron phase** chronology and the named North Ponil sites. 36

**Office of Archaeological Studies. "Data Recovery Plan for Coyote Canyon Rockshelter (LA 139965)."**

Useful because its cultural background section synthesizes northeastern New Mexico archaeology, Apache ethnohistory, and settlement shifts using later scholarship. Strong on the **Southern Athabaskan/Jicarilla** narrative and on the mountain-plains setting. 37

**New Mexico Office of Archaeological Studies / New Mexico Department of Cultural Affairs.**

Best official gateway for New Mexico archaeological reports and public archaeology mission. Essential starting point for responsible, source-based follow-up. 38

**National Park Service and U.S. Forest Service cultural-resource guidance.**

Used here for legal protection, visitor ethics, and public interpretation principles rather than site-specific Philmont chronology. Important for the "how to visit respectfully" section. 39

**Official tribal resources: Southern Ute Indian Tribe, Comanche Nation, and Jicarilla-associated public resources.**

These sources are critical for avoiding a solely outsider archaeological narrative. They help situate Philmont within living Indigenous geographies and institutions, even when open web materials do not provide a full site-specific history of the ranch itself. 40

**Official Philmont archaeology materials and guidebooks.**

Best used carefully: strong for describing what visitors actually see and how Philmont currently interprets



Indian Writings, but not always the strongest source for contested questions of authorship or symbolism.

41

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1 6 **Geology of the Cimarron Range, New Mexico**

[https://www.usgs.gov/publications/geology-cimarron-range-new-mexico?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://www.usgs.gov/publications/geology-cimarron-range-new-mexico?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

2 8 10 14 20 21 22 23 25 26 27 36 **The prehistory of northeastern New Mexico**

[https://nmgs.nmt.edu/publications/guidebooks/downloads/27/27\\_p0077\\_p0082.pdf](https://nmgs.nmt.edu/publications/guidebooks/downloads/27/27_p0077_p0082.pdf)

3 **Southwestern Region | Archaeology and Cultural Resources**

[https://www.fs.usda.gov/r03/natural-resources/arch-cultural?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://www.fs.usda.gov/r03/natural-resources/arch-cultural?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

4 38 **New Mexico Office of Archaeological Studies – A Division of ...**

[https://nmarchaeology.org/?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://nmarchaeology.org/?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

5 18 **New Mexico Statutes Chapter 18, Article 6 (2025) - Cultural ...**

[https://law.justia.com/codes/new-mexico/chapter-18/article-6/?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://law.justia.com/codes/new-mexico/chapter-18/article-6/?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

7 9 11 12 13 17 29 30 37 **nmarchaeology.org**

<https://nmarchaeology.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/468-CoyoteDRP8-14-14rvs-PUBLIC.pdf>

15 **Pinyon-Juniper Woodlands**

[https://www.fs.usda.gov/sites/default/files/pinyon-juniper-fact-sheet.pdf?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://www.fs.usda.gov/sites/default/files/pinyon-juniper-fact-sheet.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

16 **The importance of traditional fire use and management ...**

[https://research.fs.usda.gov/treesearch/23871?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://research.fs.usda.gov/treesearch/23871?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

19 **Classic Cars Displayed at Villa**

[https://www.philmontscout ranch.org/wp-content/uploads/filestore/pdf/Philnews\\_2011/PhilNews201103.pdf?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://www.philmontscout ranch.org/wp-content/uploads/filestore/pdf/Philnews_2011/PhilNews201103.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

24 34 **Historic Preservation Division**

[https://www.newmexicoculture.org/preservation/?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://www.newmexicoculture.org/preservation/?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

28 41 **Archaeologist**

[https://www.philmontscout ranch.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/10/Archaeologist.pdf?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://www.philmontscout ranch.org/wp-content/uploads/2020/10/Archaeologist.pdf?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

31 32 33 **Petroglyphs - Saguaro National Park (U.S. ...**

[https://www.nps.gov/sagu/learn/historyculture/petroglyphs.htm?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://www.nps.gov/sagu/learn/historyculture/petroglyphs.htm?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

35 **Contact Us**

[https://nmarchaeology.org/contact-us/?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://nmarchaeology.org/contact-us/?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

39 **Archaeological Resources Protection Act of 1979**

[https://www.nps.gov/subjects/archeology/archaeological-resources-protection-act.htm?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://www.nps.gov/subjects/archeology/archaeological-resources-protection-act.htm?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

40 **History – Southern Ute Indian Tribe**

[https://www.southernute-nsn.gov/history/?utm\\_source=chatgpt.com](https://www.southernute-nsn.gov/history/?utm_source=chatgpt.com)